MOTIVA HUB · FIELD GUIDE № 02

The Habit Stack Kit

A 14-page working document for people who have read the books but still don't have the habits. Pick an anchor. Stack a behavior. Remove the friction. Ship the day.

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How to use this kit

This is not a book. Books sit on shelves. This is a **worksheet you fill in with a pen, on the desk, in one sitting**. Twenty to forty minutes, and you walk out with three habits you can run for 30 days.

The framework is small on purpose:

1. **Anchor** — a habit you already do without thinking (coffee, shower, sitting down at desk).
2. **Stack** — a new, tiny behavior attached to that anchor. Two minutes maximum.
3. **Friction** — one thing in your environment that made the old attempt fail. Remove it.

> **Rules of the kit.** Fill it in one pass — don't come back tomorrow. Under two minutes per new habit. Never miss twice in a row. Track on paper, not on an app for the first 30 days (apps are the reason your last 5 attempts failed).

Everything in this kit comes from applied behavior design (Clear, Fogg, Lally), 8 years of personal protocols, and the failure reports of people who tried and quit. Nothing is theory you'll never use.

The Habit Stack Formula

The full stack is one sentence. Memorize it:

```
After I [ANCHOR],
I will [TINY NEW HABIT].
So that I become [IDENTITY].
```

Example: "After I pour my morning coffee, I will write one sentence in my journal. So that I become someone who writes daily."

Notice three things:

1. **The anchor is unambiguous.** Not "in the morning" — that's a mood. "After I pour my coffee" — that's a physical event you can point to.
2. **The new habit fits in two minutes.** Not "write 500 words". One sentence. You can scale up later, but the entry bar must survive your worst day.
3. **The identity clause is stated out loud.** Habits fail when they are only tasks. Reading "so that I become a writer" once makes the sentence feel like evidence for an argument, not a chore.

📚 **RECOMMENDED** · The full source of this method: James Clear, *Atomic Habits* — **amazon.fr/dp/0735211290**

Find your anchors

Every day has 8-12 automatic behaviors you already do daily without willpower. These are your anchors. List them:

MORNING (BEFORE NOON)

MIDDAY (NOON TO 5PM)

EVENING (AFTER 6PM)

Selection rule: pick 3 anchors max — one morning, one midday, one evening. If you pick more, you're building a schedule, not a stack. Schedules fail.

Ten stacks that survive real weeks

Morning · **After I pour my coffee, I write one sentence.** → Becomes: someone who captures thinking before it evaporates.

Morning · **After I brush my teeth, I do 10 squats before touching my phone.** → Becomes: someone whose body moves first.

Morning · **After I sit at my desk, I open ONE file, not my inbox.** → Becomes: someone who starts with the work.

Midday · **After I finish lunch, I walk 6 minutes outside — no phone.** → Becomes: someone who resets the nervous system, not just eats.

Midday · **After I close a call, I write one sentence about what was decided.** → Becomes: someone whose meetings produce artifacts.

Evening · **After I put my phone on the charger, I read 2 pages of a book.** → Becomes: someone who ends the day with input, not output.

Evening · **After I change into home clothes, I set tomorrow's top-3 on paper.** → Becomes: someone who wakes with a plan.

Evening · **After I brush my teeth at night, I write one thing that worked today.** → Becomes: someone who sees evidence for the story "I'm getting better".

Transition · **After I close my laptop, I do one 60-second stretch before standing.** → Becomes: someone whose body doesn't pay for the desk hours.

Weekly · **After Sunday coffee, I look at 7 days of my calendar for 5 minutes.** → Becomes: someone who audits the week, not just survives it.

📚 **RECOMMENDED** · For the identity-based approach: James Clear, *Atomic Habits* — **amazon.fr/dp/0735211290**. For the tiny-behavior science: B.J. Fogg, *Tiny Habits* — **amazon.fr/dp/059323484X**.

Your stack, tracked

Print this page. Fill your 3 anchors on the left. Tick a square each day you did the habit. Two empty squares in a row → shrink the habit to 30 seconds, not to zero. (Each column is a weekday, each row is one week W1..W5.)

ANCHOR 1: _____	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
W1							
W2							
W3							
W4							
W5							

ANCHOR 2: _____	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
W1							
W2							
W3							
W4							
W5							

ANCHOR 3: _____	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
W1							
W2							
W3							
W4							
W5							

Why your last 5 attempts failed

It was not motivation. It was that the phone was 30 cm closer than the journal. Behavior is mostly environment. Audit:

Bedroom

- ☐ Phone charges outside arm's reach (or in another room)
- ☐ Book is on the nightstand, not on a shelf
- ☐ Clothes for tomorrow's workout are laid out visible
- ☐ Alarm clock is a physical clock, not your phone

Desk

- ☐ Only the current project is open on screen
- ☐ Notifications disabled for non-human sources
- ☐ Notebook is on top of keyboard, not in a drawer
- ☐ Water bottle sits next to laptop (visual reminder)

Kitchen

- ☐ Fruit is at eye level; snacks are in a closed container in a cupboard
- ☐ Prep containers are visible on counter, not buried in a cabinet
- ☐ Supplements sit next to the coffee maker (anchor proximity)

📚 **RECOMMENDED** · A physical alarm clock, cheap and effective: Philips Somneo — **amazon.fr/s?k=somneo**. Phone-locking box for deep-work hours: k-lock — **amazon.fr/s?k=phone+locking+box**.

Habit stacking × environment

A stack without an environment is a wish. A stack inside a designed space is a machine. Combine them:

ANCHOR	STACK	ENVIRONMENT TWEAK
Pour coffee	Write 1 sentence	Notebook already open on counter
Brush teeth	10 squats	Mat unrolled in front of sink
Sit at desk	Open 1 file	Bookmark on that file; inbox icon removed
Close laptop	60-second stretch	Yoga block sits on the laptop itself
Change clothes	Write top-3	Pen taped to wardrobe door

> **The one-line rule.** Every habit must be pre-loaded in the physical space where the anchor happens. If it isn't visible, it isn't chosen.

📚 **RECOMMENDED** · For the environment-first framework, the classic read is Charles Duhigg, *The Power of Habit* — **amazon.fr/dp/081298160X**.

The 90-day identity test

Most people quit at day 30 because nothing felt different. Try this instead. Day 90, ask:

THE THREE QUESTIONS

1. Has the sentence "I'm someone who ___" changed for me? What did I believe 90 days ago vs. now?

2. What do people around me now see that they didn't 90 days ago?

3. If I had to keep only one of the three stacks I built — which one stays?

Interpretation. If question 1 has an honest answer, the stack worked. If it doesn't, the stack was too big or the anchor was weak. Shrink, re-anchor, restart.

Common ways this breaks

> **"I forgot three days in a row."** → Anchor was too passive. Move the stack to a more physical anchor (opening a door, sitting down, brushing teeth — not "when I feel like it").

> **"The stack felt stupid."** → Habit was too big. Cut it to 30 seconds. One pushup. One word written. Do that for a week, then grow.

> **"I did the habit but nothing changed."** → Identity clause wasn't written. Re-read the sentence "so that I become ___" out loud every morning for 30 days. Habits compound in identity, not in outcomes.

> **"I got sick and stopped."** → Restart with the smallest possible version. Never miss twice in a row after a restart; that's the actual rule.

> **"Traveling broke the anchor."** → Design a travel version of every stack: 2 squats instead of 10; one sentence in phone Notes instead of journal. Anchor stays, habit scales down.

> **"I tried 5 stacks at once."** → You're not building habits. You're doing a self-improvement project. Cap at 3. One becomes automatic before adding the fourth.

📚 **RECOMMENDED** · For the recovery protocol after a break, Dave Asprey-adjacent is not the answer. The right book is B.J. Fogg, *Tiny Habits* — **amazon.fr/dp/059323484X**.

What to use, what to avoid

For the first 30 days, paper only. After that, if a tool removes a real friction, use it:

TOOL	FOR	WHY
Streaks (iOS)	2-3 tracked habits max	Beats visual streak psychology, no gamification noise
Habitica	If games help you	RPG framing turns discipline into play
Finch	Low-energy people	Gentle self-care loops, no streak-shame
Physical journal + Leuchtturm1917	Deep work stacks	Analog anchors beat app anchors for identity-building
Todoist / Things	Task capture only	Not for habits. Habits need calendar + repetition, not lists.

> **Avoid:** habit apps with more than 5 habits on the dashboard. If the tool becomes the project, you're using it wrong.

📚 **RECOMMENDED** · Leuchtturm1917 Medium A5 dotted notebook (the one we use on the site): **amazon.fr/s?k=leuchtturm1917**

Blank 5-week grids

Print 3 of these for backup weeks. Same rule: two misses = shrink habit to 30 seconds, never to zero.

BACKUP WEEK 1	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
Habit A							
Habit B							
Habit C							

BACKUP WEEK 2	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
Habit A							
Habit B							
Habit C							

BACKUP WEEK 3	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
Habit A							
Habit B							
Habit C							

BACKUP WEEK 4	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
Habit A							
Habit B							
Habit C							

After the kit

The Habit Stack Kit is step one. If you finished 30 days, your next move depends on what actually stuck:

1. **Anchor is automatic, stack still feels forced.** → Shrink the stack to 30 seconds and run 30 more days. Do not grow it yet.
2. **Stack is automatic, but you didn't get the outcome.** → Wrong identity clause. Rewrite it. "I'm someone who writes" is different from "I'm someone who writes to think clearly."
3. **Stack is automatic and you got the outcome.** → Add the fourth habit only after 30 more days of the three. Slow is fast.

> **Recommended next document:** our 30-day discipline PDF (free) — the-motivahub.com/30-days-discipline.pdf. It runs one small challenge per day and pairs perfectly with this framework.

Full book list, podcast episodes, and free templates: **the-motivahub.com**

About the author

Youssef Raihane writes Motiva Hub — a self-improvement library for people who already know the theory and want working protocols. The site publishes 169 long-form articles on habits, discipline, deep work, and the physical side of the mind.

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